

Spain Itinerary

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Barcelona: Where Football, History, and Chocolate Collide

Day 1: 21st March

Gothic Quarter, Gaudí & Sagrada Família

We touched down in **Barcelona** around 1 p.m., and within minutes, the city's heartbeat was unmistakable—**football**. It wasn't just a sport here; it was a language, a religion, a way of life. Kids dribbled balls down alleyways, adults wore jerseys like second skin, and conversations about the game flowed like poetry. For any football lover, it felt like coming home.

Getting our bearings took some time—as it does when you land in Europe and have to figure out the first bus on limited sleep and unfamiliar signs. We eventually made it to our apartment, which, in hindsight and now with several stays behind me, I'd call “decent.” The host won us over a bit with milk chocolate, though.

There was no time to rest. At 4 p.m., we had a **GuruWalk** booked—a free walking tour with a local guide. I was running on fumes, dragging my feet more than walking, but I'm so glad we went. Our guide led us through the **Gothic Quarter**, the oldest part of the city, where **Barcelona was born**. Before diving into the Gothic alleys and Gaudí wonders, we made a quick stop at one of Barcelona's most heartwarming hidden gems—the **Kissing Wall** (*El Muro del Beso*). At first glance, it looks like a romantic mosaic of two people kissing. But step closer, and you'll see it's made up of **thousands of tiny photos**, each capturing moments of **freedom, love, and everyday life**.

Created by artist **Joan Fontcuberta**, the mural is titled “*The World Begins With Every Kiss*”, and it's a powerful reminder that even in a bustling city, **intimacy and connection matter**. It was the perfect way to start our journey—art, emotion, and a little surprise tucked into a quiet corner of the city.

We wandered past **ancient Roman walls**, stood in the shadow of the **Cathedral of Barcelona**, and paused at **Plaça del Rei**, where royalty once ruled. The highlight? The **Bishop's Bridge**, a fairytale-like archway that looks like it was plucked straight from a fantasy novel. It was designed by **Joan Rubió i Bellver**, a disciple of Antoni Gaudí, to complement the Gothic Quarter's historic vibe. Rubió was frustrated when his grand plan to transform the entire area into a Neo-Gothic wonderland was rejected. In protest, he allegedly carved a **skull pierced by a dagger** under the bridge—meant to **curse anyone who walks beneath it**. Some even whisper that the skull might be real! The bridge's design was inspired by the **Bridge of Sighs** in Venice, giving it a romantic and dramatic flair that makes it one of the **most photographed spots** in the city. It was also featured in the “*Zindagi Na Milegi Dobara*” movie.

Just when we thought we were getting a grip on the city's ancient charm, we stumbled upon something... unexpected. Tucked into a souvenir shop window was a tiny figurine of a man squatting with his pants down. Meet the **Caganer**—a traditional Catalan Christmas figure that's been raising eyebrows (and chuckles) for centuries.

Yes, you read that right. The Caganer, which literally means “the pooper,” is a beloved part of Catalan nativity scenes. It might sound bizarre, but locals see it as a symbol of **fertility, humility, and the natural cycle of life**. It's quirky, unapologetically human, and somehow, it fits perfectly into Barcelona's blend of tradition and rebellion.

Only in Barcelona can you go from **Gothic cathedrals** to **cheeky figurines** in the span of a few blocks.

Just a few steps away, in **Plaça de Sant Miquel**, we came across something that stopped us in our tracks—a towering sculpture made entirely of wire, frozen in a moment of breathtaking balance. This was the **Monument als Castellers**, a tribute to one of Catalonia's most awe-inspiring traditions: **human towers**, or *castells*.

The sculpture captures the essence of this centuries-old practice, where teams of people—called *colles*—form multi-tiered towers by climbing on each other's shoulders. It's not just a feat of strength and coordination, but a symbol of **community, trust, and Catalan pride**.

As we admired the wire sculpture of the Castellers, something clicked—it reminded me of Dahi Handi back home in India. Both traditions involve forming human pyramids, both require immense coordination and trust, and both are deeply rooted in cultural pride. Different continents, different stories—but the same spirit of community, courage, and celebration.

As we wandered further, we came across a street performer who had completely mastered the art of illusion. He stood frozen, mimicking the effect of a **powerful gust of wind**—his clothes billowing, his posture tilted, as if nature had paused mid-chaos. I have no idea how he pulled it off, but it was absolutely mesmerizing.

It's moments like these that make Barcelona feel alive. The city isn't just about grand architecture and deep history—it's about the **unexpected magic** that happens on its sidewalks. Whether it's a human statue defying gravity or a musician playing flamenco in a quiet alley, **Barcelona performs for you**, even when you're not looking for a show.

As the sun dipped lower, casting golden light across the city, we found ourselves face-to-face with some of **Barcelona's most iconic architectural marvels**—each one a masterpiece, each one a story carved in stone.

First up was **Casa Amatller**, a lesser-known gem with a façade that looks like it belongs in a chocolate box (fitting, since it was built for a chocolatier!). Right next to it stood the surreal and dreamlike **Casa Batlló**, designed by the legendary **Antoni Gaudí**. With its **wavy lines, mosaic tiles, and dragon-like rooftop**, it felt like stepping into a fantasy world.

And just when we thought we'd seen it all, we reached **Casa Milà (La Pedrera)**—a bold, undulating stone structure that looks like it was sculpted by wind and water rather than human hands. No straight lines, no sharp corners—just pure, flowing creativity.

Barcelona doesn't just build buildings—it **tells stories through architecture**. Every balcony, every curve, every tile has a purpose. And walking past these masterpieces, you can't help but feel like you're inside an open-air museum curated by genius.

As our guided tour came to an end, we decided to **explore on our own**, letting the city lead us wherever it pleased. On the way back to our apartment, the irresistible scent of fried dough pulled us into a tiny **churro shop**. And honestly—**when in Spain, fry it up and sugar it down**, right? Crispy, golden, and dipped in thick chocolate, it was the perfect pick-me-up after a long day of walking.

Our apartment was just a short stroll from the **majestic Sagrada Família**, so we wandered over to see it bathed in the **golden hour glow**. Even from the outside, the basilica is breathtaking—its spires reaching skyward like a stone forest, each detail more intricate than the last. We snapped a few photos, stood in awe for a while, and let the moment sink in.

Though our day in Barcelona came to a close, the city still holds a few secrets we've yet to uncover. Luckily, we'll be back—our flight to Rome departs from here, giving us one more chance to soak in the magic.

That was more or less it for Day 1. Since we landed midday and started exploring by 4, it felt like a sprint in slow motion. Back at the apartment, we began the dance of backpack repacking—a first for us, ditching the wheels for straps. It's chaotic, this life out of zippers and cubes, but we're still figuring it out. Still hustling through it.

Sleep came fast. Our alarms were set for a **6 a.m. train to Madrid** the next day—and we needed every bit of shut-eye.

Until then, **adiós, nos vemos**.

Day 2: 2nd April

A Chilled Farewell to Spain

Date: 2nd April 2024

Our time in Spain was coming to an end, and we had an early morning train from Madrid to Barcelona. Since we had our first internal flight from Barcelona to Rome the next day, we chose a hostel near the airport. It was a bit far from the city center, but the owner assured us there was an early morning bus right outside that would take us directly to the airport—perfect for our early flight.

After checking in, we got ready for our **last day in Spain**—bittersweet, but we were determined to make the most of it. First stop: **Indian brunch**. There's something incredibly comforting about familiar spices when you're far from home.

Next, we made our way to the **official FC Barcelona store**—a pilgrimage for any football fan. But wow, talk about premium pricing! Jerseys, scarves, mugs... and then we saw it: **a patch of stadium grass for €50**. Yes, actual grass. For fifty euros. We laughed, we gasped, we walked away.

From there, we headed to **La Boqueria**, Barcelona's most famous market. A sensory overload in the best way—**fresh fruits, jamón, seafood, juices, and sweets** all under one colorful roof. It's the kind of place where you go in for a snack and come out with a full stomach and a camera roll full of photos.

To wind down, we walked toward the **beach**, letting the sea breeze and sound of waves wash over us. As we neared the beach, we stumbled upon the towering **Columbus Monument**, where **Christopher Columbus points dramatically toward the sea**—though fun fact, he's actually pointing away from the Americas! It's one of those iconic landmarks that makes you pause, snap a photo, and wonder about the stories behind it.

We spent some peaceful time at the **beach**, soaking in the sun, clicking photos, and letting the Mediterranean breeze carry away the fatigue of travel. It was the perfect blend of relaxation and reflection.

From there, we explored the nearby areas and made our way to **Plaça de Espanya**, one of Barcelona's grandest squares. There, we saw the **Arenas de Barcelona**, a former **bullring** that's now a stylish **shopping center**. The transformation from tradition to modernity is striking—and very Barcelona.

Our final stop was **Poble Espanyol**, an open-air architectural museum that showcases replicas of buildings from different regions of Spain. It's like walking through a mini-Spain in one afternoon—**Andalusian courtyards, Galician houses, Castilian plazas**—all in one place. A beautiful way to wrap up our journey through Spanish culture.

For dinner, we found a cozy **vegan café** with unlimited soft drinks—a fun little bonus. It was a chilled-out evening, the kind that lets you slow down and savor the moment.

Back at the hostel, we packed our bags for Italy, feeling a mix of excitement and nostalgia. Spain had given us so much—history, food, culture, and memories we'd carry forever.

Must-Visit Places in BARCELONA

If you ever find yourself in Barcelona, here are some incredible spots to explore:

- **Sagrada Família:** Gaudi's iconic spires.
- **Park Güell:** Vibrant colorful mosaics.
- **Gothic Quarter:** Historic medieval streets.
- **Casa Batlló:** Whimsical dragon rooftop.
- **La Rambla:** Stroll down the lively avenue.
- **Montjuïc Hill:** Magnificent panoramic vistas.
- **Camp Nou:** FC Barcelona's legendary home.
- **Picasso Museum:** Picasso's early artistic works.

Madrid: A City of Magic, Memories, and Meaning

Madrid welcomed us at 8:28 a.m., unfolding its marvellous charm right from the station. A local explained the city's transport card system—flexible passes for 24 hours, trip-based recharges, or longer durations. After comparing options, we chose a card with a set number of trips, something we hadn't explored in Barcelona but promised ourselves to use next time. Our hostel, **Newton Guesthouse**, was warm and inviting, with clean spaces and a vibrant hostel culture. Arriving early, we stored our bags, freshened up in the washroom, and stepped out to discover the city.

Since Madrid is vast, we chose the **Hop-On Hop-Off bus**, the perfect way to get a sweeping view of the city before diving deeper. The ride unfolded like a moving gallery of history, politics, art, and modernity.

Day 1

Historic Landmarks & Monuments

Riding across the lanes of Madrid, several iconic structures caught our attention, each displaying centuries of architectural details and history:

- **Puerta del Sol – King Charles III Statue** – This equestrian statue of King Charles III stands proudly in Puerta del Sol, one of Madrid's busiest squares. Charles III is remembered as the "best mayor of Madrid" for his reforms and modernization of the city in the 18th century. The fountain and lively plaza around the statue make Puerta del Sol a vibrant hub, and it's also the symbolic "kilometer zero" of Spain's radial road system.
- **Metropolis Building** – The ornate Beaux-Arts style building with the black dome and golden accents is the Metropolis Building, one of Madrid's most photographed landmarks. Located at the corner of Gran Vía, it's a symbol of the city's elegance and architectural grandeur. The winged statue atop the dome makes it instantly recognizable.
- **Puerta de Alcalá** – A neoclassical triumphal arch near Retiro Park, with five arches and sculptural details commissioned by King Charles III in 1778. Located near Retiro Park, it's a symbol of the city's history and grandeur, and the bus route makes sure you don't miss it.
- **Plaza de Cibeles & Palacio de Cibeles** – One of Madrid's most iconic squares, at its center is the Cibeles Fountain, with the Roman goddess Cybele riding a chariot pulled by lions. Around it stands the grand Palacio de Cibeles, now the City Hall. The fountain is a symbol of Madrid, often associated with Real Madrid football celebrations. On the bus tour, this is a highlight stop because it blends history, art, and modern city life.
- **Biblioteca Nacional (National Library)** – The grand building with statues of San Isidoro and Alfonso el Sabio is the National Library of Spain. It's one of the most important cultural institutions in the country, housing centuries of manuscripts, books, and archives. The neoclassical façade and statues reflect Spain's intellectual heritage. Passing here on the bus connects you to Madrid's scholarly side.
- **Congreso de los Diputados** – The bronze lion statue in front of the neoclassical building is part of the Congress of Deputies, Spain's lower house of parliament. The lions are famous symbols of strength and guardianship. Interestingly, they were cast from bronze taken from cannons captured in the War of Africa in 1860. Passing here on the bus gives you a glimpse of Spain's political heart and its architectural grandeur.

- **Ministerio de Agricultura** – The ornate building labeled Ministerio de Agricultura (Ministry of Agriculture) is another architectural gem. With its red brick, white stone detailing, and dramatic statues of winged figures and horses on top, it's one of Madrid's most striking government buildings. The Hop-On Hop-Off bus route often passes here, showcasing the grandeur of Spain's administrative heritage.
- **BBVA Building** – It represents Madrid's financial and business side, contrasting with the historic architecture in the city center. Passing by it on the bus route gives you a sense of how Madrid balances tradition with modernity.
- **Santiago Bernabéu Stadium** – Home of Real Madrid, a global icon of football, currently being transformed into a futuristic arena.
- **Julia Sculpture (Plaza de Colón)** – The large white segmented head with closed eyes is "Julia", a modern sculpture by Jaume Plensa. It stands prominently near Plaza de Colón and symbolizes serenity and reflection amidst the bustle of the city. It's striking because it contrasts Madrid's historic monuments with contemporary art, showing the city's evolving identity.

The bus gave us not just convenience but also context—Madrid's past, present, and future unfolding in one ride. By lunchtime, we had completed both lines, enjoyed a hearty meal, and even treated ourselves to bubble tea. But the real highlight awaited us at Plaza del Sol—a GuruWalk tour that would leave a lasting imprint on our hearts.

Xavier and the Art of Reawakening

We joined a Guru Walk tour that afternoon, led by a man named **Xavier**—who turned out to be a piano teacher, theatre artist, and musician with a storyteller's soul and the presence of a quietly confident protagonist. He walked us through **Puerta del Sol**, the streets fanned out like arteries from the city's not-quite-center, and through the cobbled veins of old Madrid with an energy that made us forget our fatigue.

At Puerta del Sol, he stopped us at the **Km 0 plaque**, the symbolic origin of Spain's radial road network. Nearby, he pointed out the whimsical **Reloj del Viajero** on Calle de la Sal—a quirky clock from 1880 that embodies the spirit of travelers and the passage of time. We continued into the grand expanse of **Plaza Mayor**, framed by symmetrical facades and towers, with the bronze equestrian statue of King Philip III at its heart.

From there, Xavier led us down Calle de Cuchilleros, where history hides in plain sight. We paused at **Restaurante Sobrino de Botín**, recognized as the oldest continuously operating restaurant in the world, its oven burning for centuries without pause. Just a few steps away stood **El Kinze de Cuchilleros**, a traditional barbershop with red-and-blue poles. Xavier explained how barber shops once doubled as wound-healers, stitching injuries when doctors weren't available—a detail that made us see the poles in a whole new light.

Further along, he pointed out **Reina Madre**, a shop with ornate wooden paneling and shelves of skincare products. It wasn't just about what they sold—it was about the tradition of century-old businesses marked by plaques, proof of Madrid's living heritage. In fact, Xavier showed us one such brass plaque embedded in the pavement outside a storefront, a marker that silently testified to the longevity of businesses that had survived more than a hundred years.

We also passed a historic building with flags and a statue of a man holding a sword, its stonework and gardens reflecting Madrid's political and cultural pride. And then, in a lighter moment, Xavier introduced us to the quirky Caganer shop, filled with figurines of the famous Catalan nativity character in humorous poses. The name "*El Caganer*" literally means "the pooper". The Caganer, by creating

faeces, is fertilizing the Earth. It was a reminder that Spanish culture is not only about grandeur and tradition, but also about humor and playfulness woven into everyday life.

At one stop, we even encountered a bronze statue polished by countless playful hands, where visitors often pose with laughter. *El Vecino Curioso*, or “The Curious Neighbor,” is a bronze of a middle-aged gentleman created by sculptor Salvador Fernández Oliva in 1999. He appears to be leaning on a railing and looking down at the archeological remains of Santa María de la Almudena, the first church to be built in Madrid. The statue is anchored directly to the sidewalk, without a base.

Unfortunately, only a few remnants of the original church survived after it fell victim to the construction work on Calle de Bailén in 1868. What's left is visible through a protective glass case, into which this curious neighbor peers. The statue's underside is polished from the many times it has been touched. Some say this is out of habit, others think it brings good luck. The statue has spent several decades in the same place, practicing the national sport of pensioners: “watching the works.”

Finally, as the tour drew to a close, Xavier led us toward the **Almudena Cathedral**, its dome and towers glowing in the sunset. From the hilltop, we looked out across the **Royal Palace and Almudena together**, the rooftops bathed in golden light, while locals and tourists sat on the grassy terraces enjoying the view. It was the perfect ending—Madrid's grandeur softened by the warmth of dusk.

The way he spoke—about Madrid's history, its superstitions, long-lost empires, the plates outside century-old shops, and tiles that told time—was electric. We heard about the Hemingway Hotel dilemma (so many cafés claiming his legacy, others proudly saying “This is not Hemingway's”), the world's oldest restaurant with a century-old oven still burning, and even a story about how barber poles once represented their ability to stitch wounds, back when doctors weren't available.

He painted history with humor and precision, weaving in tales of Roman sewer systems, royal traditions like raising flags to signal the King and Queen's presence, and the quiet legacy of beliefs and churches scattered across the city's spirals.

But it wasn't just the stories. It was how they made us feel.

For two hours, I forgot I was tired. It felt like sipping a mug of black coffee brewed with purpose. Even now, when I think of Madrid, I think of Xavier. His passion stirred something restless in me, tugging at that quiet, persistent question—What is my passion? How do we find it, and more importantly, how do we keep living in service of it? It was one of those rare moments when a tour guide becomes a mirror—reflecting back your own unfinished thoughts with clarity.

We ended the tour at sunset on a hilltop, golden light washing the rooftops below. Harshit gently suggested we take a picture with Xavier, but I hesitated. I wanted the memory to stay soft-edged, not frozen. Some people aren't meant to be saved in pixels—they linger better in passing thoughts.

Before parting, we took his recommendations for food and Seville, his hometown. Then we walked back toward our hostel, quiet, thoughtful, and a little changed.

Day 2

Final Trains, Money Heist Moments & Sweet Goodbyes

Date: 1st April 2024

Our last day in Europe began in the quiet stillness of dawn—so early that the streets of Seville were still asleep. With no buses or trams running at 5 AM, we booked our very first Uber in Europe. It felt like a small milestone, a modern convenience marking the start of a day that already carried a sense of finality. The ride through empty streets was surreal—lamps flickering against cobblestones, shutters closed tight, the city holding its breath while we slipped away toward the station.

We arrived well ahead of time, but just as boarding began, travel reminded us of its unpredictability. One of our bags was flagged as oversized. The language barrier made the situation frustrating, and the staff's curt attitude didn't help. After a few tense exchanges, we had no choice but to pay extra. It soured the mood briefly, a reminder that even adventures have their hiccups. But we shook it off—after all, this was our last European sunrise, and we weren't going to let bureaucracy steal it.

By 10 AM, Madrid welcomed us back like an old friend. We returned to our familiar hostel, freshened up, and grabbed breakfast before setting out for something we had been anticipating for weeks—the **Money Heist trail**. Walking through the filming locations of *La Casa de Papel* felt surreal. The **Bank of Spain**, the rooftops, the plazas—they weren't just backdrops anymore, they were living spaces we could touch, walk through, and breathe in. Every corner carried echoes of the Professor's plans, every façade felt like a memory from the screen suddenly made real.

The day unfolded with a mix of fandom and farewell. We strolled through **Madrid's central park**, letting its greenery soften the edges of the city. We wandered aimlessly like locals, revisited the epicenter plaque at Puerta del Sol, and let the city's vibrant pulse sink into us one last time. Madrid wasn't just a stopover anymore—it had become a place layered with stories, both fictional and personal.

As evening settled, we treated ourselves to a final Spanish dinner, savoring every bite as though it were a ritual. And then came dessert—**churros dipped in thick chocolate, flaky pastries, and sweet indulgences** that felt like a farewell kiss from Spain itself. It was a gentle, delicious closure to a journey that had given us more than just sights—it had given us memories, questions, and a deeper sense of connection.

Must-Visit Places in MADRID

If you ever find yourself in Madrid, here are some incredible spots to explore:

- **Puerta del Sol:** Symbolic heart of Madrid.
- **Plaza Mayor:** Historic square with cafés and performers.
- **Royal Palace:** Stunning architecture and ceremonial traditions.
- **Prado Museum:** Masterpieces by Velázquez and Goya.
- **Retiro Park:** Green escape with lakes and sculptures.
- **Gran Vía:** Shopping, theatres, and nightlife.
- **Sobrino de Botín:** The world's oldest restaurant.
- **Local Food:** Tapas, churros with chocolate, and cocido madrileño.

Seville: Orange Blossoms, Gothic Spires, & the Soul of Flamenco

Day 1: 30th March

Arrival, Seville Cathedral & Torre del Oro

Our bus from Faro to Seville was scheduled for 10 AM. The walk to the station wasn't long, but every step carried the weight of farewell—we were leaving Portugal with backpacks full of memories and hearts still lingering in its rhythm. Just as we settled into our seats, the skies opened up. Rain poured down in sheets, drumming against the bus windows. It felt poetic, as though Portugal itself was reluctant to let us go, sending us off with a watery embrace.

We reached Seville around 2 PM, and the journey wasn't quite over yet. Our apartment lay a little outside the city center, so another hour passed before we arrived. But the moment we stepped inside, fatigue melted away. Our host welcomed us warmly into her pristine white apartment—everything spotless, glowing with care. Three curious cats padded around, eyeing us like new characters in their territory. She shared tips on where to catch an authentic flamenco performance and what corners of the city deserved our attention. It felt less like checking into a rental and more like being received into someone's home.

Before reaching the cathedral, we paused at a striking fountain crowned by a bronze sculpture of a reclining woman, naked yet serene, reading a book. The water cascaded down stone steps beneath her, turning the scene into something both contemplative and playful—a reminder that Seville's art isn't confined to galleries, but woven into its public spaces. It was a curious, unexpected encounter, and it set the tone for the city's blend of history and creativity.

From there, we made our way to the **Seville Cathedral**, its towering Gothic presence surrounded by a sea of people. The cathedral is not only one of the largest in the world but also a UNESCO World Heritage Site, built on the site of a former mosque. Its sheer scale is overwhelming—ornate stone carvings, massive arched windows, and the famous **Giralda bell tower**, which once served as a minaret, rising proudly above the skyline. Inside, the cathedral houses treasures of art and faith, including the tomb of Christopher Columbus. On Easter evening, however, the focus was outside: the *pasos* (religious floats) carried through the streets, candles flickering, incense drifting, and brotherhoods in traditional robes moving with solemn rhythm. Witnessing the Crucifixion float, richly decorated with gold and lifelike figures, felt like stepping into centuries of devotion and craftsmanship.

After leaving the cathedral and wandering through the festive streets, we made our way toward the **Torre del Oro**, the iconic golden tower that once guarded Seville's riverfront. Crossing the bridge nearby, we paused for photos with the tower rising behind us and the Guadalquivir River flowing steadily below. It was one of those moments where history and everyday life blended seamlessly—the medieval watchtower standing as a reminder of Seville's maritime past, while the modern city bustled around it.

After soaking in the atmosphere, we let the city guide us. A light drizzle began, softening the edges of the cobbled streets and turning them into shimmering pathways. Seville's orange trees glistened under the rain, their fragrance mingling with the damp air. We wandered aimlessly, letting the city's rhythm carry us, until hunger led us to a cozy spot for dinner. The table quickly filled with dishes that looked promising:

- **Nachos** – a generous plate layered with melted cheese, ground meat, tomato sauce, and herbs. It was hearty and flavorful, the kind of dish made for sharing.

- **Burger** – beautifully presented on a slate board, stacked with a juicy patty, melted cheeses, fresh arugula, tomatoes, and a crispy fried element. It looked gourmet, almost too pretty to eat, and though rich, it was far better than the disappointing burger we'd had earlier in Toledo.
- **Creamy Salad** – a traditional-style mix of diced potatoes, carrots, peas, pickles, and mayonnaise, topped with olives. Comforting and filling, it carried that festive, homely touch that made it feel like a Spanish twist on familiar flavors.

Dinner was a mix of indulgence and curiosity, each dish adding its own note to the day's rhythm. With full stomachs and tired legs, we headed back to our Airbnb, where the quiet of the apartment and the company of our host's cats felt like the perfect close to a day spent between rain, celebration, and history.

Day 2: 31st March

Stories in Stone & the Soul of Flamenco

Date: 31st March 2024

We started the morning with a quick coffee and dessert at **La Campana**, a historic pastry shop that has been serving locals since the 19th century. Sweet energy in hand, we joined our **Guruwalk tour**, led by a guide recommended by someone we met in Madrid. He was engaging, full of fascinating insights, and made the city's history come alive.

As we walked, Seville unfolded in layers of architecture and stories:

- **The Giralda & Seville Cathedral** – The Giralda tower, once a minaret during the Moorish period, now rises as the cathedral's bell tower, blending Islamic and Christian styles in one breathtaking structure. The cathedral itself, one of the largest Gothic churches in the world, stood as a symbol of Seville's wealth and devotion, its intricate carvings and rose windows dazzling against the sky.
- **The Archbishop's Palace & Baroque Facades** – Just beside the cathedral, the Archbishop's Palace and nearby ornate government buildings showcased Seville's Baroque grandeur. Elaborate stonework, statues, and decorative balconies reminded us how power and faith intertwined in the city's past.
- **The Old Tobacco Factory** – Our guide pointed out the imposing building that once housed Europe's largest tobacco factory. It's now part of the University of Seville, but centuries ago it was the center of Spain's tobacco trade, employing thousands of workers and inspiring stories like Bizet's *Carmen*.
- **Semana Santa Traditions** – Along the way, we learned about the rituals of Holy Week. Brotherhoods carry pasos (floats) through the streets, some depicting scenes like the Crucifixion, richly decorated with gold and lifelike figures. The guide explained how incense, music, and devotion transform the city during Easter, making it one of the most important celebrations in Spain.
- **The Legend of Susona Ben-Suson** – In the narrow lanes of Barrio Santa Cruz, we stopped before a modest white façade marked with a tile showing a skull and crossbones. Here, our guide told us the haunting story of Susona, the daughter of a wealthy converso family who betrayed her father's plot against the Inquisition to her Christian lover. Her confession led to executions, including her father's, and she lived the rest of her life in remorse. Before her death, she asked that her skull be displayed on her home as a warning of betrayal. For centuries, it hung there, and today the tile keeps her story alive. Standing in front of that wall, listening to the tale, felt like stepping into Seville's darker, more fragile past—a sharp contrast to the grandeur of the Cathedral and the joy of Easter processions.

- **Voyages to India & Beyond** – Standing near the river, he spoke of the historic voyages that left Seville and Lisbon, connecting Spain and Portugal to India and the wider world. It was fascinating to hear how these journeys shaped trade, culture, and even the food we eat today.

Every story made me want to revisit our own history with fresh eyes, seeing the threads that connect continents and centuries. By the end of the tour, Seville felt less like a city of monuments and more like a living museum—its streets echoing with faith, commerce, and art. After the tour, we went for a vegan lunch and continued exploring the city—visiting churches, observing prayers, and climbing the **Seville Tower** for panoramic views. The city was alive, yet peaceful. Every corner had a story, every street a rhythm.

After exploring Seville's historic core, we wandered toward the riverfront near the **Torre del Oro**, the “Golden Tower” that once guarded the city's port. Its name comes from the golden shimmer it cast on the water centuries ago, when it was part of the city's defensive walls. Today, it stands as a proud reminder of Seville's maritime past, watching over the Guadalquivir River where ships once set sail for the New World. Nearby, we found a replica of the **Nao Victoria**, the first ship to circumnavigate the globe, commemorating the 500th anniversary of Magellan and Elcano's voyage. Standing before its towering masts and rigging, with rain falling softly, felt like stepping back into the age of exploration.

By then, hunger had caught up with us, so we stopped for lunch at a cozy spot that served vibrant, flavorful dishes:

- **Vegan Bowl** – A colorful mix of avocado slices, roasted chickpeas, sautéed mushrooms, shredded cabbage, carrot ribbons, cucumber, and a creamy hummus dip. Sprinkled with seeds and topped with crispy vegetable chips, it was as nourishing as it was beautiful—a rainbow of textures and flavors in one bowl.
- **Arepas** – Cornmeal patties filled with avocado and fresh vegetables, served on a decorative plate with a creamy dip in the center. Soft yet hearty, they carried a Latin American flair that felt both comforting and adventurous.

Lunch was a perfect balance—healthy, satisfying, and full of character. With the river and Torre del Oro nearby, it felt like we were tasting Seville's global spirit, a city shaped by voyages, trade, and cultural exchange.

With lunch behind us, we continued exploring Seville, letting the city reveal more of its character. We came across two towering stone columns topped with statues, standing proudly in an open plaza. These are known as the **Columns of Hercules**, a historic landmark dating back to the 16th century. They symbolize Seville's connection to classical mythology and its role as a gateway to exploration. The plaza around them was lively, with trees, food stalls, and people strolling—an everyday rhythm unfolding around monuments that have watched centuries pass.

Our walk then led us to the **Basílica de la Macarena**, a striking Baroque-style church painted in white and ochre tones. Its ornate façade, statues, and bell tower immediately caught our eye. Inside, the basilica houses the revered image of the Virgin of La Esperanza Macarena, one of the most beloved figures in Seville's Semana Santa processions. The devotion here was palpable, and it gave us a deeper sense of how faith shapes the city's identity.

Later, we found ourselves on a bridge spanning the Guadalquivir River, with the modern Torre Sevilla rising in the background. The cloudy sky and cool breeze gave the scene a moody atmosphere, contrasting with the vibrant streets we had just left. Standing there, looking out over the river and the mix of old and new architecture, felt like a quiet pause—a reminder that Seville is a city where history and modernity coexist in harmony.

As evening approached, we were early for our flamenco show, so we decided to grab dinner first. The restaurant served us a **vegetarian pizza**, thin-crust and colorful, topped with cherry tomatoes, zucchini, mushrooms, and melted cheese. Rustic and fresh, it was the kind of dish that felt both comforting and artisanal—simple ingredients elevated by flavor and presentation. Sharing slices over conversation, we felt the anticipation building for the night ahead.

The show had open seating, so we made sure to return early—and it paid off. We secured **front-row, center seats**, close enough to feel the vibrations of every stomp.

This was our first live flamenco performance, and it was everything we hoped for and more. Flamenco had always intrigued me—especially after seeing it in *Zindagi Na Milegi Dobara*—but watching it live was electric. The stage glowed under blue and purple lights, and the performers commanded it with raw intensity.

One woman sang with piercing emotion, her voice carrying pain and pride in equal measure. Two dancers moved with fierce precision—the woman in a flowing green dress striking dramatic poses, her hands slicing the air, while her partner mirrored her energy with sharp footwork. Behind them, the guitarist's strings and rhythmic clapping created a heartbeat that pulsed through the room. We didn't understand the lyrics, but the emotion transcended language. Passion, sorrow, resilience—it was all there. For two hours, we were spellbound, carried away by a performance that felt less like entertainment and more like a cultural revelation.

After the show, we stepped back into the cool night air, still buzzing from the energy. We took a quiet stroll through the city, crossing a bridge where the river reflected the golden lights of Seville's skyline. The historic towers and modern buildings shimmered together in the water, a perfect backdrop to end the day. Standing there, with the city glowing behind us, we felt both exhilarated and at peace.

Finally, we headed back to our apartment to rest—our early morning train to Madrid awaited, but Seville had already left its mark on us.

Must-Visit Places in SEVILLE

If you ever find yourself in Seville, here are some incredible spots to explore:

- **Alcázar of Seville:** Wander through royal gardens and palaces.
- **Seville Cathedral:** Marvel at the largest Gothic cathedral in the world.
- **Plaza de España:** Take in the grandeur of this magnificent plaza.
- **Metropol Parasol:** Experience modern architecture and great views.
- **Barrio Santa Cruz:** Get lost in the charming old quarter.
- **Torre del Oro:** Visit this historic watchtower by the river.
- **Flamenco Dance Museum:** Immerse yourself in the passion of flamenco.
- **Maria Luisa Park:** Relax in this beautiful public park.

Toledo: A Day of Slow Beauty & Reflections

As I sit at Milan airport, waiting to board our flight home, the last 18 days blur around me like sunlit snapshots from a moving train—equal parts adventure, chaos, beauty, and quiet reflection. Memory is already hazy, but I know that once I start writing, it will bloom again, vivid and alive.

Our final Spanish adventure took us to **Toledo**, and like every “last day,” it began with good intentions and a late start. The comfort of our Madrid hostel kept us lingering. The dormitory bunk beds, with their quirky motivational poster—“*Life is too short not to be the mushroom you want to be*”—had already become part of our travel rhythm. Before leaving, I even cooked rice and dal, our first proper comfort meal of the trip. Sitting down to steaming bowls of lentils and fluffy rice felt grounding, a taste of home after weeks of tapas, pastries, and café meals.

At the bus station, Spain reminded us of its quirks: long queues, silent ticket machines, and no staff in sight. Honestly, it felt familiar—like India, where patience and improvisation are part of the journey. We managed our tickets, hunted down the platform, and joined the snaking line. And then came Harshit, in classic “Harshit mode,” maneuvering us to the front with quiet confidence. One elderly couple shot us a glare sharp enough to pierce stone, but we laughed it off. Travel karma, we decided, had already balanced itself somewhere else.

By 11 a.m., Toledo unfolded before us—a world apart from Madrid. The moment we stepped off the bus, a hush fell. From the capital's bustle to Toledo's slow rhythm, it felt like stepping into another century. Cobbled streets wound through ancient walls, golden light bounced off stone that had stood for hundreds of years, and the air carried a stillness we hadn't realized we needed.

Day 1

Discovering the City on Our Own Terms

We had a planned tour at **Plaza de Zocodover** that was canceled due to low turnout, but that turned into a gift. The square itself felt like the perfect starting point—Toledo's beating heart, once a marketplace for goods and livestock, later a stage for festivals, announcements, and even bullfights. Today, it's alive with cafés spilling onto cobblestones, locals weaving through tourists, and the hum of conversation echoing against historic façades. Standing there, we felt the pulse of Toledo's everyday life, a vibrant contrast to the quiet alleys and solemn cathedrals.

A local guide handed us a hand-drawn map, offered food recommendations, and with that, we curated our own walking tour. For the first time on our trip, every step was ours to decide. Cathedrals, watchtowers, courtyards—we stitched together our own path through history. Our legs ached by the end, but our hearts were full.

Somewhere in a quiet alley, I made a mistake I'll never repeat: ordering bubble tea in Europe. It was watery, sad, and out of place. The shop owner was Korean, and it struck me—why drink a Korean treat in a Spanish city, when both cultures have such rich culinary stories? That was my last bubble tea of the trip, and I carried no regrets.

Before heading deeper into the city, we stopped at the **Posada de la Hermandad**, a medieval building whose stone façade seemed to carry centuries of stories. Once the headquarters of a brotherhood, today it hosts exhibitions that bring Toledo's past vividly to life—swords, catapults, and relics of medieval warfare displayed alongside banners honoring figures like King Fernando III. Standing before its carved stone entrance, with heraldic shields and ornate detailing above the arch, felt like stepping into a portal where civic duty, faith, and history intertwined.

Just beside it stood the **Archbishop's Palace of Toledo**, equally commanding in its own way. Its stately balconies and ornate façade reminded us that Toledo was not only a city of worship but also a seat of ecclesiastical power, where religion and civic life intertwined. The palace seemed to anchor the square, a silent witness to centuries of decisions that shaped the city's destiny.

From there, we made our way to the **Alcázar of Toledo**, its fortress towers rising with an authority that felt unshakable. The stone walls carried the weight of battles, resilience, and reinvention. In front of it, a solemn monument stood—a statue holding a cross-like structure, stark against the backdrop of the fortress. It was a reminder that Toledo's story is not just one of beauty, but of endurance, faith, and strength carved into stone.

After hours of wandering Toledo's winding streets and capturing photos against its medieval backdrops, we finally slowed down by the banks of the **Tagus River**. The water shimmered under the afternoon light, framed by cliffs and greenery, offering a moment of calm after the city's uphill climbs. Sitting there, with the sound of the river flowing steadily beneath us, felt like a pause in the day—a chance to breathe and let the city's beauty sink in.

Hunger eventually pulled us away, and we chose a restaurant with outdoor seating, hoping for a leisurely Spanish lunch. We waited about 10–15 minutes before our food arrived: a vegan Spanish-style stew and a burger. The skewer was decent, but the burger turned out to be the worst we'd ever tasted—dry, bland, and utterly forgettable. We laughed it off, deciding it would be remembered not for its flavor but for the story it added to our trip.

With our stomachs filled (if not satisfied), we continued our exploration and made our way to the **Puente de San Martín**, one of Toledo's most iconic medieval bridges. Stretching across the Tagus with its grand stone arches, the bridge was built in the 14th century and once served as a vital crossing into the city. Standing on it, gazing at the river below and the city rising in the distance, we felt the weight of history under our feet. The bridge wasn't just a passage—it was a monument to Toledo's resilience, connecting centuries of travelers just like us.

On our way back to the station, we stumbled upon a wedding outside a church. It was cinematic—silk gowns, camera flashes, quiet awe. We lingered just long enough to see the bride step out, radiant against the backdrop of Toledo's timeless streets, before melting back into the crowd.

By 6 p.m., we were back in Madrid—tired, hungry, but content. Our hostel offered a bar-hopping event that night, but we passed. That's never been our scene. Still, I'd recommend it to anyone who loves nightlife—it looked lively, full of music and laughter. Instead, we grabbed dinner at a nearby café, packed our bags, and rested before boarding our overnight bus to Porto. The hostel staff were kind enough to let us store our luggage for free and use their lounge and washroom in the evening. Those small kindnesses matter more than they seem—they soften the edges of travel.

Now, as I type this from Milan, with a plane waiting and my mind spinning through memories, I know this trip will stay with me. We didn't just see places—we moved through them, carrying our own little universe in backpacks, chasing stories down alleyways, and watching sunsets that made us feel both tiny and infinite.

Spain—you were vibrant, messy, soulful. **Toledo—you slowed us down in all the right ways.**

And now, onward to Portugal...

Must-Visit Places in TOLEDO

If you ever find yourself in Toledo, here are some incredible spots to explore:

- **Alcázar of Toledo:** A historic fortress with sweeping views.
- **Toledo Cathedral:** Gothic grandeur with intricate details.

- **El Greco Museum:** The art and legacy of El Greco.
- **Puente de Alcántara:** An ancient Roman bridge still standing.
- **Monastery of San Juan de los Reyes:** Beautiful Gothic cloister.
- **Synagogue of Santa María la Blanca:** Jewish history in Toledo.
- **Plaza de Zocodover:** Beating heart of public life.
- **Posada de la Hermandad:** Medieval weapons exhibition hall.

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